

THE SEVEN CARDINAL SINS

Greetings, God bless you, my dearest friends. Blessed is this hour. I promised to give a psychological explanation of the meaning of the seven cardinal sins. Much of what I shall say will not be new. I shall try to keep repetition to a minimum and to do so only when it is necessary to show a connection and to show the deeper meaning of spiritual truth in a psychological sense.

What is called sin is the outer manifestation, either in deed or even in thought, of psychological deviation and immaturity. In other words, the result of inner distortions produces so-called sin. The psychological background of any sin will always show the many conditions that we discussed in the past. It can always be brought down to the common denominator of sin amounting to the immaturity of the soul and thus being incapable of relating, communicating, loving. In the broadest terms sin is lack of love. Immaturity is never able to love. It is selfish, egocentric, blind. It cannot understand others. It means separateness. In separateness, one does not love and is therefore in sin. In psychological terms, one has a neurosis. The only difference between the spiritual and psychological approach is that the latter puts emphasis on the result, while the former shows the underlying causes, the different currents and components leading to separateness, neurosis, or sin.

The first cardinal sin is pride. This I have discussed so much in the past that I do not have to repeat it now. You all know its origin, reason, its effects, and side effects. Let me only state once again briefly that pride is always a compensation for inferiority, for feelings of inadequacy. That the effect must lead to separateness is self-explanatory.

The second is covetousness. Again, from past lectures, you know its deeper meaning. If you covet something you do not possess, you do so in blindness -- blindness in the belief that having it would give you happiness, when happiness is an inner state, never to be brought by outer means. And blindness is ignoring your own causes as to why you do not have what you wish to have. In your search for self-understanding, you have come to the point of realization that whatever you lack in your life, provided your wish is a healthy one, is caused by conflict within yourself -- by being, perhaps unconsciously, afraid of the very thing that you want most or by having conflicting desires, by being unaware of many factors that obstruct the fulfillment. Last but not least, you may be unaware of what you really wish. Under these circumstances, you may envy others, covet what they have because you cannot resolve your very own problems that keep you from fulfilling yourself. What you covet may be a substitute desire for your real needs of which you may not be aware. Pride, as well as covetousness, separates you from the other person, as well as from your real self. Hence, it leads to and comes from self-alienation. It is the opposite of love, of communication, of relating to your fellow man. It does not unite, but sets you apart and above. It puts you in a special, isolated place, or you would wish to have the special place that you think someone else holds. All this is the inner blindness that leads to outer selfishness and to separateness.

The third is lust. This is so often misunderstood. It is believed to refer to sexuality. This is not so, or not necessarily so. Now, what does lust mean? It means any kind of passionate desire -- whether or not it has to do with sexuality -- in a spirit of egocentricity, of isolation. It is the childish attitude of "I want to have, to receive" without a true spirit of mutuality. The person may be willing to give, provided he receives what he wants, and yet the basic emphasis is subtly on the self rather than on mutuality. True mutuality is not possible without the capacity to relinquish, to withstand not always having one's will on one's own terms. The maturity of withstanding frustration of one's will, of relinquishing one's will, is a prerequisite for true mutuality. When the need to receive is a greedy force that is intrinsically one-sided, then one can speak of lust.

As I have often said, it is easy to be deceived because the stronger this one-sided need exists, the more may the person sacrifice, submit, be a martyr. All this is an unconscious expediency so as to get one's will. Since this tendency is subtle and hidden and often has nothing to do with sexual passions, it may not be realized that it is lust. Yet all human beings have some of it. Where there is a forcing current, a driving need that cannot relinquish, there is lust. And you all have that, the stronger when it is not yet consciously experienced. Also you may be deceived about it because what you strenuously desire is in itself something constructive. Yet, you are the craving needful child who wants, who is somehow in the center of his universe. The raging need, which you may or may not be conscious of, is disconnected from recognizing the factors that brought about the original unfulfillment. In this ignorance, the need, or lust, swells to unbearable proportions and becomes more frustrated because you do not see the remedy -- a change of inner direction. In other words, an unfulfilled need that is unrecognized in its primary form produces lust. To the degree that you grow aware of your needs do you automatically increase your maturity. An unconscious need indicates immaturity. A displacement takes place, and an urgency for substitute needs is established, no matter how legitimate, constructive, or rational they may be in themselves. The stronger the urgency, the more one can speak of lust. Lust indicates the urgency of frustration of an unaware need. Whether this refers to sexuality or the lust for power, money, for being liked, for a particular thing, does not matter. When these emotions are investigated as to origin, their original need, and what prevents their fulfillment in a healthy organic manner, you can begin to dissolve the lust. You can come to terms with the original need, but never with the substitute need. If this original need is still childish and destructive, you can mature it only by bringing it out into the open. A need that you are aware of can mature into a mutuality, into the state when two people recognize and express their own respective need in such a way as to help the other find fulfillment. An unconscious need must always be one-sided.

To assume that the sexual urge per se is sinful lust, is utter distortion. As I have often said, it is a natural healthy instinct. If it properly matures, it combines with mutuality. It leads to love and union. If it remains separate, it is lust, but no more so than the lust for power, for money, for fame, for always being right, or for anything else.

The fourth is anger. What is anger, my friends? Anger is always, in a sense, a lie. The original feeling is often one of hurt. If you would own up to the original feeling, you would not need to be angry. In pride, due to inferiority, you feel humiliated when you are hurt, in that you give the power to hurt you to someone else. Therefore you substitute the original pain with anger. This seems less shameful. It sets you above the other person rather than, as it seems to you, below. It lifts you above the true position you find yourself in -- that of being hurt. In pride, you lie about your real

feeling. Thus anger and pride are connected. The lie is one of self-deception, therefore of self-alienation. It is displacement. Thus it causes negative effects, while the admission, the living up to the genuine feeling, does not. Hurt, if it is free from anger, cannot negatively effect others, and therefore it will not come back to the person. If the primary emotion -- pain or hurt -- is no longer conscious or if it is intermingled with the secondary emotion of anger, it turns destructive. Whether the anger manifests in deeds or words or whether it is merely an emanation, makes no difference. In owning up to hurt, you do not cut off the bridge to the other person. In anger, you do. Thus the genuine, primary emotion is not contrary to love and communication, while the substitute emotion is.

You know that I usually shy away from the expression "sin" because it encourages self-destructive and unproductive guilt. I concentrate rather on the underlying conditions. But in this context, I have to use this word. Thus anger leading away from communication and bridging of the gap between human beings, is sin.

Of course, there is such a thing as a healthy anger, but we do not talk about that. There really should be another word for it.

And now, my friends, I'm ready for your questions.

QUESTION: Why is it that in the Bhagavad Gita anger is considered worst of all, producing complete confusion?

ANSWER: Because in anger, being a secondary reaction, you no longer know what you really feel. You are in error about yourself, and therefore you cannot possibly perceive and understand the other person. In many of the other so-called sins, you may be utterly aware of the original feeling. Due to certain missing links, you may be unable to feel differently about it, yet you know what you feel. But when you are in anger, you are not in the primary reaction. And that is why it creates more and more confusion. It is even worse, of course, if your perfectionism makes you repress even the secondary emotion of anger so that you are not even aware of it. Then you have to penetrate all these levels and first become aware of the anger, whereupon you can then penetrate deeper and become aware of the underlying hurt or pain.

I might also add that many of the other destructive emotions, whether it be jealousy, envy, lust, etc., also contain anger. Anger may be a permeating state of the soul that is too subtle, too insidious, too hidden to be recognized. Thus when I admonish you on this path to become aware of what you really feel, you will now understand this all-important reason. Whether you call it resentment, or hostility, or anger, or hate makes no difference. These are all the same. The majority of human beings are not even aware that they feel, that they are in anger. When they are aware of it, it is already so much better. It is then easier to get to the underlying original emotion.

QUESTION: What is healthy anger?

ANSWER: It is the anger that is objective, when justice is at stake in an objective way. It makes you assert yourself. It makes you fight for what is good and true -- whether the issue is your own or another's or for a principle. You may even feel objective anger about a very personal issue, while projecting a subjective emotion upon a general issue. How to determine whether or not it is

healthy anger is impossible by judging the issue itself. You feel very differently in healthy anger than you do in the unhealthy kind. The latter poisons your system; the latter calls for your defense mechanism and is at the same time a product of it. Healthy anger will never make you tense and guilty and ill at ease. It does not compel you to justify yourself. Healthy anger will never weaken you. Any healthy feeling will give you strength and freedom even if the feeling outwardly appears to be negative. While an apparently positive feeling may weaken you if it is not honest, if displacement and subterfuge are at work. If you have the kind of anger that will leave you freer and stronger and will leave you less confused, then there is a healthy anger. The unhealthy anger is always a displacement of an original emotion. Healthy anger is a direct emotion.

QUESTION: Is that the wrath of God in the Old Testament?

ANSWER: Yes, that is right.

QUESTION: Does that have anything to do with righteous indignation?

ANSWER: Yes, that is also healthy anger. But, my friends, be very careful in your self-examination. When you have an outer issue in which you may be utterly justified in feeling angry, that may still not mean that what you feel is healthy anger. The only way to determine it is by the effect it has on you and also on others. No one but yourself can determine what is the truth. Only utter candor with yourself will enable you to distinguish.

The fifth is gluttony. The deeper meaning of it has to do with need. A need that is unfulfilled and frustrated for a long period of time, and again and again thwarted, as it were, will seek outlets. Such an outlet, among many other possibilities, may be gluttony. Why would ancient wisdom refer to this as sinful? Not merely because it is destructive of your physical health -- that would certainly not be sufficient reason to call it a sin. There are many activities in a person's life which are undesirable and damaging to his health, yet they are not considered as sin. Something much more important and vital is at stake here. That is, if you are unaware of your original needs and therefore cannot go about fulfilling them through the removal of your inner obstructions, you cannot fulfill yourself. You cannot fulfill your potentials. You cannot become happy and give happiness. You cannot unfold your creative abilities. You cannot contribute, be it in ever so small a way, to human society and its development. Every human being, no matter how much you may look down on him or may think his existence insignificant for others and that he cannot possibly contribute anything, does have the possibility to contribute in some way to the evolutionary plan. But only if he fulfills himself can he do so. He cannot fulfill himself when he is unaware of his real needs, and then without the understanding of why these needs remain unfulfilled. As he understands it, bringing fulfillment closer and closer, by this understanding, he contributes something to the vast reservoir of cosmic forces, thus influencing evolution and general spiritual development. The fulfillment of every human being, his happiness, is a necessity for the entire evolution.

When people are unfulfilled and therefore unhappy, it would be one-sided to say that this is selfishness. It may be that too. It may be a childish self-concern too. Yet there is another part of the psyche that realizes the necessity of happiness, that knows that only in happiness can one contribute, and therefore by not contributing, one misses something. This gnawing feeling of missing something makes you strive. He who strives in the right direction will eventually find a way to turn inward and seek the reason for this unfulfillment. But there are many wrong ways of striving

that lead outward, that bring temporary relief of the inner pressure. One of them is gluttony. As I indicated previously, there are many other forms of addiction, such as alcoholism to name but one.

QUESTION: Some psychologists say that masturbation is a primary addiction. Is this connected with gluttony?

ANSWER: I should say this very much depends on the degree and on the age. If this is a constant practice in an advanced age, it certainly has a lot to do with it although the displacement of the real need is not quite as remote as with gluttony. It is easier to see that the real need is a yearning for a rewarding mutuality on a mature basis. With gluttony, the displacement is so far removed that it is more difficult to recognize the underlying real need. However, masturbation is also a substitute. It may be an easy way out to obtain relief and release without risking the involvement of a personal relationship, the responsibility, the exposure. To a degree, masturbation is normal. But above a certain degree, depending on the frequency and the age of a person, as well as certain temporary circumstances in life, it may indicate a similar escape from facing and living up to one's real need. If it is a constant practice in adult life, it is certainly indicative of the same trends and aspects discussed in connection with gluttony.

The sixth is envy. Again I do not have to go deeper into this because I have covered it before. What I said about covetousness very much applies to envy. I also discussed envy on many previous occasions.

QUESTION: Is there something like healthy envy?

ANSWER: No, there is not. It might, under certain circumstances, lead to a healthy activity. Let us say, someone is without ambition -- and there is such a thing as a healthy ambition. He is lethargic, withdrawn, apathetic indifferent, and he comes into contact with someone whom he feels compelled to envy. This may pull him out of his lethargic state and perhaps even put him in the right direction. It may be that a destructive feeling may have a constructive result, just as it may be that a feeling, in itself constructive, may have an unhealthy effect. This may or may not be the case. It depends on the many intricacies of the human personality in relation to his life circumstances. But the fact that a destructive feeling may produce positive results in certain cases does not make the feeling itself positive, healthy, or productive per se.

QUESTION: That is a problem of the twist into the pairs of opposites?

ANSWER: Yes, that is right.

The seventh is sloth. It is the very indifference and apathy that I just mentioned. It represents the pseudosolution of withdrawal from living and loving. Where there is apathy, there is a rejection of life. Where there is indifference, there is the laziness of the heart that cannot feel and understand others -- and cannot, therefore, relate with them. Nothing produces more waste than sloth or apathy or withdrawal, whatever name you give it. A person would not be in sloth who has a positive, constructive attitude towards life. Someone who is not overly preoccupied with his own safety, will not withdraw, and therefore will not become apathetic. Sloth always indicates selfishness. He who is too afraid for himself will not risk going forward and reaching out towards others. The one who reaches out takes the risk of being hurt. He considers it worthwhile. In sloth, you do not

give to life, to yourself, and to others, a chance. You cannot ever bestow happiness upon others in this self-preoccupation that seeks the pseudosolution of withdrawal or apathy or sloth. This is life-negating. Such life-negation cannot ever be resolved unless the person comes to see this basic selfishness and self-concern is unhealthy. Sloth is one of the defense mechanisms I have discussed. In your fear of being hurt, you defend against it by becoming lazy of heart, indifferent towards everything that is life-producing. Therefore it is rightly called a sin.

QUESTION: What happens with a life, from a spiritual point of view, that has been wasted in sloth?

ANSWER: The same has to be repeated again and again until the person finally pulls himself out of it. You see, the same law applies here that you can so often observe around you. The more you are caught in a vicious circle, the more difficult is it to break. The deeper you are involved in your own conflicts and problems -- which, in the last analysis, arise only because you do not want to come out of them and change -- the more difficult it finally becomes. The more you have run away from facing up and have continued to resist change, the greater the difficulty. This continues until your outer life becomes so unbearable, as a result of your getting deeper and deeper into the vicious circle, that this very unhappiness finally makes you want to face and change. If the will can be mustered before life becomes so unbearable, much unhappiness could be avoided. This is why you often see that people persist in remaining caught in their inner problems as long as they somehow "get by." They seriously settle down to changing only when it is no longer bearable for them. The same holds true on a larger scale. If a life is wasted in sloth time after time, finally the circumstances of an incarnation may become so unpleasant that the individual pulls himself together and struggles out of it. Unfortunately, only too often though, sloth produces the attitude of the life of least resistance so long as circumstances are not too bad. This creates for the following life the psychological conditions that make it harder to live in sloth because then the instinct of self-preservation takes over when it becomes bad enough. When that pulling out occurs depends on the person. It may be before life becomes really unbearable. Such are the psychological conditions that you yourself have created. The turning point may come in a new and more difficult incarnation, or it may occur in the course of the present incarnation.

QUESTION: I was wondering why some of these deadly sins are effects instead of causes. And, for instance, hatred and fear are not mentioned. They too are cause and effect at the same time.

ANSWER: It is so often with religious teachings that the effect is spoken about, and not the cause. At one time, humanity was not ready to go deep enough to see the cause. The best that could be hoped for was to prevent people from destructive actions even if the underlying causes were not eliminated in the individual. At least, the contagiousness of actions and direct outer effect of destructive actions were decreased, if not entirely eliminated. You know how contagious is human behavior. Thoughts and emotions are also contagious, but on the same level. In other words, outer behavior will influence outer behavior, while thought influences thought, or unconscious feelings influence unconscious feelings. At least, the contagious actions in the crassest form were kept in check. That is why, at one time, the effect was more concentrated on than the cause. Now that humanity is evolving, more attention must be given to the inner causes.

QUESTION: And why is fear not mentioned?

ANSWER: Because it is not an act. It is an emotion that cannot be helped. It is a result of many other emotions and cannot be eliminated by a direct admonition to have no fear. Fear can only be tackled by a process of psychological understanding, and by dissolving the underlying roots. If you tell a person, "You must not fear because it is a sin," this will not prevent him from being frightened. He will become even more frightened. But if he slowly unrolls the processes of his emotional deviations, understanding them, correcting his false concepts, he will first see that irrational fear is always selfishness and separateness. Further, he will no longer find cause for such irrational fear. It is more or less the same with hate. Besides, hate is very much the same as anger.

QUESTION: The conquest of fear in Matthew is by way of faith in God. How would you relate that to our teachings?

ANSWER: As you all know by now, faith in God in a genuine, secure, profound, and sincere way can only exist if you first have faith in yourself. To the degree that you lack faith in yourself, you cannot have faith in God. Yes, you can superimpose it, deceive yourself about it out of a need to cling to a loving authority, but in a realistic genuine way it cannot be unless you have gained the maturity of faith in yourself. Now, how can you have faith in yourself unless you understand yourself as much as this is possible. As long as you are puzzled and grope in the dark about the effect you have on others and the effect life and others have on you, you ignore some vital information about your own psychic life. And this ignorance is a result of your inner unwillingness and often unconscious resistance to find out the truth. Only in overcoming this hidden resistance and unwillingness will you get to understand better, have increasing faith in yourself and thus in God. Only in this way can you conquer fear.

QUESTION: It seems to me that the seven cardinal sins are a subtler explanation of the Ten Commandments, which are definitely based on fear or create fear in their application.

ANSWER: Yes. Every teaching, if misapplied and misunderstood, will create fear. A rigid commandment pronounced without affording the person the possibility of finding out the underlying obstructions to following the ideal of such commandments, rather than eliminate the causes, will produce fear and guilt and therefore hate. Today it is no longer possible and constructive for man to merely obey a commandment in action. Since this is not good enough, your innermost self will be in fear even if your actions are entirely proper and conform to the commandments. The final authority is not outside of yourself, but embedded in your own psyche. And there is a vast difference between the superdemands of your idealized self and its perfectionism, and the reality of the productive life that your real self wants you to lead.

QUESTION: I noticed that these sins you listed are liquid. They sort of flow into each other. Sometimes they seem like opposites, like sloth contrasted with covetousness or with gluttony. They are not exact opposites, but they are in some ways opposites. And yet they can exist at the same time. I wonder if there is any definite connection, say, between sloth and gluttony?

ANSWER: They are opposite because gluttony is a greedy reaching out due to a frustrated need, while sloth is indifferent withdrawal and does not reach out. Yet they have the same common denominator of unawareness of the original need; cowardice to find it and change the conditions necessary to bring fulfillment; childish self-concern and selfishness. Since both come from

confusion and disorder -- the displaced, unconscious real need -- they create further confusion and disorder.

It is perfectly true that all these sins intermingle, overlap. They may contradict and yet exist simultaneously. This is so because they all have the same common denominator. Since the human personality is in conflict and not one-sided, one aspect of the personality may adopt an attitude that is contradictory to another. All of you have found such contradictions in yourselves and in others. This is why a mature person will never think another person is either this or the other. He will perceive the contradictoriness of the human being as such and will be able to apply it to individual cases in his surroundings.

These sins, as well as any commandments, represent universal tendencies. Since the human psyche is not separated into clearly defined compartments in which one compartment has nothing to do with the other, but one affects and influences the other, so it is with these sins.

QUESTION: From what you said then, there is really no difference in weight between these seven deadly sins? Sometimes it is said that sloth is worse than pride.

ANSWER: It is difficult to evaluate this. It may be misleading. It may be true, as you can easily see, that sloth is more difficult to get out of because it is inactive. It paralyzes the faculties and is thus of longer harm. But as such, all of them are symptoms of the same underlying causes.

QUESTION: I wanted to ask about the fear of the Lord. In the Bible it is said that "The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom." Have we properly understood the fear? Have we evolved beyond this?

ANSWER: This question has been discussed before. It is a question of semantics, of wrong translation. The word fear is extremely misleading and damaging. The original sense is "respect" or "awe" before the greatness of the Creator. The infinite greatness is such that no human being can possibly or even remotely understand. As you grow in emotional and spiritual maturity, you realize your own limitation in understanding the greatness of creation and of the Creator. That is the awe or respect that comes out of wisdom, but not in the unhealthy sense of making yourself a small "sinner," of flagellating yourself, or diminishing your own value. Because if you do so, you diminish the value of the Creator. It is only the very immature, the spiritual infant, who does not know that it cannot possibly grasp the universal mind, God. The more mature do know it. And that is wisdom. As you grow, you sometimes, perhaps a few short moments in a lifetime, sense your incapacity of grasping. As you are aware of this incapacity, in that moment you are much greater than when you ignore this incapacity.

QUESTION: Is not the fear of the Lord an element out of the ancient religions where religion had a punitive character?

ANSWER: Yes, it also comes from that time. But it is also a question of wrong translation, perhaps just because of the remnants of that time.

QUESTION: How about sin from the spiritual point of view. If you don't commit the sin, but if you think about, it, but you don't actually commit it, out of fear or any other reason, is this the same?

ANSWER: Jesus has said all there is to say about it. The difference between action and feeling or thought is not half as great as man wants to believe, especially when noncommitment is due to fear and not due to love and to understanding, or at least an attempt at it. You all know that you have an emanation. What you feel and think emanates from you and is somehow always perceived by others. The more the consciousness of a person is raised, the more aware may the other person be of what he perceives from you. The less his consciousness is raised, the less will he be aware of it, but unconsciously he knows. Hence your "sin" affects others even if it is not committed. Yet, on the other hand, if you repress these feelings and desires out of fear and guilt, it is even worse. You will never get to the roots, you will not understand what makes you feel that way. You will not accept yourself as you now are and will deceive yourself into believing that you are a more evolved person than you happen to be. But if you freely admit it, if you acknowledge it in yourself, you face it, and from there on, you can find the underlying reason. Thus you will do the only thing that will free you of it.

QUESTION: In today's "Post," someone wrote something to the effect that conformity is not living in a house similar to your neighbor's, but rather living in that house in order to impress your neighbor or to make your neighbor like you. I think this is probably an adequate explanation of conformity. Now, I would like to know how far does the mature person, how much, to what extent does he conform with the society in which he lives?

ANSWER: If we use the word conforming in the sense in which it is usually used, that of living up to other people's expectations or what he thinks these expectations to be, either out of a need to impress or out of fear of rejection, the mature person will not conform at all. But that does not mean that he rebels. Nor does it mean that he does everything differently from others. He may do certain things in the same way as his neighbor, but only because he freely chooses to do so. He genuinely likes to do so. Just because he is free, he does not have to make a show of proving he does not conform. The conforming person may often find it necessary to rebel and do the very opposite of what he wants to do merely to show that he is different. This manifestation is merely the other side of the coin and contains the same root as the person who cannot make an independent choice because he cannot risk being different. Once again, the outer manifestation does not show whether or not a person conforms. It is the inner spirit, the motive, that matters. If someone lives in a way similar to his environment, it may be out of the insecurity of needing to conform. Or it may be out of the freedom of independently choosing this way of life because he likes it. If someone does everything differently out of rebellion, it shows the underlying need to conform. In reality, he rebels against this need and insecurity in himself rather than against society. This rebellion then is unfree. It often makes the person do the very opposite of what he really wants to do. But it is also possible that the person who has the courage to be different does so out of a free spirit.

QUESTION: This question pertains to the "one and only love." The mature person, it seems, gives love very easily and certainly would want something in return. If a person is, let's say, 75 percent mature and he gets this wonderful feeling from giving love, then it seems that the object of the love is not of so much importance. How could such a mature person with the need to give

love, wants to give it, is able to give it, reconcile this with the fact that romantics say two people come together, then suddenly this is it!

ANSWER: There is a great deal of confusion here. In the first place, there are many different kinds of love. It is perfectly true that a mature person can love many people in many different ways. For clarity's sake, let us use the word warmth and understanding. This can even be felt for people who do not actively love this mature person in return. Yet, this very same mature person will certainly not harbor erotic love, the love between the sexes, when it is not reciprocated. A mature, rewarding relationship is mutual. It cannot be one-sided. It would be a crass misunderstanding to believe the mature person can love if he is hated. The best that can be expected is that he will not hate in return because he is not defensive. He is uninvolved and objective and therefore senses why the other person hates even if he ignores the factors and the facts. But he will not seek a relationship in such a case, not even one of casual friendship. The mature person will have understanding and warmth in different degrees for different people. He will relate to many people in different ways. But in marital love, mutuality is a prerequisite for a mature relationship. This does not mean that both always feel the same way and with the same intensity; this cannot be measured in such terms. Relationships change and fluctuate, but on the whole there must be a reciprocity. You bring two different kinds of love together here -- general human relationship and erotic love -- and this is why the confusion exists.

QUESTION: In marital love, is it possible that perhaps the husband loves more at first, and then the wife, and then it changes again?

ANSWER: Of course. But this may also have to do with something other than love in its true sense. It may be that at one time the need and insecurity of one person may be greater, and he then manifests dependency. When this is satisfied, the picture may change. This may not have anything to do with love.

QUESTION: Isn't the greatest and best adjusting factor in marital relationship the ability to slowly grow into and see God in the other partner?

ANSWER: This applies to any kind of human relationship.

QUESTION: I'm growing aware of a new kind of feeling. As depressions, fears, and repressions dissolve, there emerges a personality that has no personal involvement and feelings so that you realize love is like a kind of negation and positiveness -- two sides -- both of which are personal involvement with the self as the object. Then love becomes an understanding and a nonpersonal involvement so that you see a stranger you would not like particularly and you have no personal involvement with this person. It is just a sort of an acceptance. Then when you have a personal relationship, this is simply a growth between two people without the "who loves most" and rejection. It is a deep personal giving. It is the most interesting feeling. It is the sort of feeling as though you have lost your body.

ANSWER: Yes, it is as though someone else feels in you and spreads this feeling into you, as though some new being takes hold of you, inwardly. You may perhaps experience the same with thoughts, as though a thought is thought in you, as though it is not your own thought process that thinks, and yet so very much your own, but it comes from a new and unaccustomed area of your

being. It is something calmer and wiser that thinks and feels and spreads it through you. This is what I talk about again and again and again. It is the real self that is slowly coming to the fore, emerging out of all the layers of disturbance. As you learn to understand and accept yourself as you are, and therefore resolve conflicts -- not by repression and escaping from them, not by pseudosolutions and defenses, but by squarely facing all that is in you, understanding it, and comparing it with reality and truthful concepts -- as you go through this process of work, this real self begins to manifest. What you describe is this manifestation of the real self. Now, this does not come in all areas of living and being at once. It may first appear in the areas where conflicts of lesser seriousness have been resolved. The next step will be to resolve the more serious problems where a deep, subjective, and destructive involvement still exists, even if noninvolvement is a superficial pseudosolution. However, in the new state of the real self, deep involvement exists, but in an entirely different way; in a way that does not weaken and confuse; in a way that is productive for all concerned and that fills you and those in touch with you, with a meaningfulness you could not experience in noninvolvement or in childish dependency and overinvolvement.

From a certain point of the path, you may find yourself on a sort of plateau when you experience the result of your efforts, when you experience this manifestation of the real self. Yet, you may have to come away from it again as you tackle the still unresolved problems, repeating the cycles you have gone through on a deeper level until you reach the next plateau. At a time like this, as you describe it, the feeling I spoke about before, the awe of God, the realization of one's own limitation to grasp the Creator, may come simultaneously. A divine aspect in yourself begins to fill you, first with a feeling as though it were something else and then penetrating, enveloping you from inside out until you know it is an integral part of you -- your real self.

QUESTION: If a man marries and he is not really deeply in love with this woman, is this wrong? Secondly, is it possible that with proper guidance, this marriage could turn out well? Is it possible that they then fall in love, that it develops into a real love affair even though it was started rather coldly?

ANSWER: It is very hard to answer with a definite statement of right or wrong. It depends on so many circumstances. It depends on the motivation; on the kind of feelings you do have; on the will and effort that is put into the relationship. But generally I may say, in some instances, if the motivation is good and the feelings of affection, respect, liking of the other human being exist, and certain common basic interests prevail, and the goal is a sincere one, as well as the motive, this may indeed perhaps turn out into a better marriage than one based on passion only. In the latter, the real values may be overlooked. Yet, this does not mean if two people are in love, they necessarily overlook the real values. They may have fallen in love just because of them. What you say is certainly not a rule, but it is possible under certain circumstances if real values are perceived. But a careful examination should be made in such a case, as to the motivation in both people. This cannot be quickly and easily done because deep and hidden factors may play a role. Even distorted and unhealthy motives when finally put out into the open may not have a damaging effect after they are looked at and come to terms with. But they will be extremely damaging if one is unaware of them.

My dearest friends, may you succeed in absorbing and making an integral part for yourself of the material I have given you in all of these lectures. Much of it has not been absorbed yet, and only your will to plow ahead in this work of self-finding will enable you to do so. May these words tonight fortify your understanding, in your intellect and in your emotions. Be blessed, each one of

you, on your path, in your work, in your activities, in your human relationships. May you all learn to accept yourself as you are without a feeling of sin, and in this acceptance resolve the conditions that are called "sin." Be in peace. Be in God!

For information to find and participate in Pathwork activities world wide, please write:

The Pathwork® Foundation
PO Box 6010
Charlottesville, VA 22906-6010, USA
Call: 1-800-PATHWORK, or
Visit: www.pathwork.org

The following notices are for your guidance in the use of the Pathwork® name and this lecture material.

Trademark/Service Mark

Pathwork® is a registered service mark owned by The Pathwork Foundation, and may not be used without the express written permission of the Foundation. The Foundation may, in its sole discretion, authorize use of the Pathwork® mark by other organizations or persons, such as affiliate organizations and chapters.

Copyright

The copyright of the Pathwork Guide material is the sole property of The Pathwork Foundation. This lecture may be reproduced, in compliance with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy, but the text may not be altered or abbreviated in any way, nor may the copyright, trademark, service mark, or any other notices be removed. Recipients may be charged the cost of reproduction and distribution only.

Any person or organization using The Pathwork Foundation service mark or copyrighted material is deemed to have agreed to comply with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy. To obtain information or a copy of this policy, please contact the Foundation.